

Prayer

This lesson is the sixth in the series entitled “The Beginner’s Bible Study.” Other lessons in this series can be obtained through the Lehigh Valley Baptist Church.

The lessons are designed to be first studied, then the questions in the back answered, and then reviewed with the help of an older Christian.

***“As ye have therefore received Christ Jesus
the Lord, so walk ye in Him.”***

Colossians 2:6

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I John 5:14-15 says, *“And this is the confidence that we have in him, that, if we ask any thing according to his will, he heareth us: And if we know that he hear us, whatsoever we ask, we know that we have the petitions that we desired of him.”*

For the life of a Child of God, the first area of attention ought not to be the prayer life, but ought to be their “Bible life.” When you read the Bible, the Bible is God talking to you. When you pray, that is you talking to God. But if I have to make a choice between reading my Bible and praying, I’ll take reading my Bible every time. The reason is because God has a lot more important things to say to me than I have to say to Him.

God has not only told me that I ought to pray, but He has given me promises and encouragement in the Word of God to pray. God wants to talk to us, but He also wants us to talk back to Him. How would it be if you were married to a wife or a husband, and you did all the talking and they never, ever spoke back to you one single word? There are some Christians who live their life almost that way with God, very seldom ever talking to Him. Those are also the people, normally, that do not spend any time reading the Word of God. The two really go hand in hand.

God is not looking for length in your prayers. Some folks, to hear them pray, you would think that they are never going to quit. The prayer is so dull and dry and lifeless it’s just words strung together to try to get length out of it.

God is not looking for beauty in your prayer, either. Some folks think, “I’ve got to put all the words together properly, and if I don’t say the right words at the right time, then the prayer isn’t going to mean anything.” The truth is, God is not interested in how beautiful your words are or how long your prayer is. .

There are basically two things God desires you to have in your prayer life. Number one, He wants your prayers to be **scriptural**. In other words, they ought to be prayers that are based on the Word of God. Number two, He wants your prayers to be **sincere**. It should be from the heart. God is not interested in hypocrisy.

Suppose you have a thousand dollar bill in your pocket, and you don't have any need for that thousand dollar bill, it is just something you have tucked away for a rainy day. Then you are praying for some brother who has a need for ten dollars, and you pray, "Oh, God, give them ten dollars." That is not a sincere prayer when you have plenty of money in your pocket to be able to meet that need. That is not sincere at all.

God is looking for our hearts to be real. When we talk to Him we need to realize that we are in His presence. He wants our prayers not to be trying to impress the people around us, but prayers that are simply talking to Him and asking from Him the things that He has promised us.

IDENTIFICATION FOR PRAYER

You have probably heard a Christian finish their prayer with, "In Jesus' name, Amen." I'm afraid that for many, it is just something they say out of habit. But that is not the way God intended it. God intended that when we use the phrase, "In Jesus' name," we understand that there is a wealth of meaning behind it.

In John 14:13-14 we read, "*And whatsoever ye shall ask in my name, that will I do, that the Father may be glorified in the Son. If ye shall ask any thing in my name, I will do it.*" That is the promise of the Lord Jesus Christ that if we will pray in His name, the Father will hear and answer our prayers.

What does it mean to pray in the name of Jesus Christ? It means first of all that you have the right to use His name. We can go to the Father in the place of Jesus Christ and say, “Jesus sent me.” That is what you are saying when you say “In Jesus’ name.” You are saying “Jesus sent me to get this.” You are taking the place of Christ.

The only people who have that right are those who are properly related to Him, those who have been born again, those who have been put into the family of God. Those are the only folks who have the right to pray. A lost man has no right to come to God in prayer except one prayer, and that is the prayer of faith in the matter of salvation, asking God for salvation. No other prayer does God promise to answer for a man that does not know Jesus Christ.

But if you know Jesus Christ, you have the promise that Jesus Christ has put His whole life, His honor, His work, everything He has accomplished behind His name. He has handed you His name and said, “Now, take my name to the Father, and when He asks what you want, you tell Him what you want and then you tell Him I sent you to get it!” That, my friend, means an awful lot.

If I went down to the bank and said, “I need a hundred thousand dollars,” the banker would look at me and say, “Sorry, I can’t give you that kind of money.” Why not? Well, because I am not worth it, quite frankly. I can understand that. So I go find a very rich man to go down to the bank with me who says, “I’ll co-sign.” Then the banker says, “Well, if you want a hundred thousand dollars, I’ll give it to you on his name.”

Likewise, Jesus comes in and He says, “You use My name. You go to the Father in My name.” When I go to the Father, I don’t go to the Father because of what Doug Hammett has done to get my prayers answered.

It's not because of my goodness. It's not because of my abilities. It's not because of what I have earned with God. But I go for one reason, one right gets me into heaven to ask of God, and that is what Jesus Christ has already done.

As you and I pray, we are praying in the name of the Lord Jesus Christ. Our prayer life actually is the greatest resource that we as Christians have. It is the greatest resource that we could ever desire. We have a resource at our fingertips of being able to go to God Almighty who has created everything, who can do anything. A God with whom nothing is impossible. We have a God we can go to and ask of Him anything that is needed! We have the name of the Lord Jesus Christ, which buys us an entrance into the Father so that He will do anything that we ask of Him.

IMPORTANCE OF PRAYER

How often should we pray, then? Paul says, we ought to pray without ceasing. I don't think Paul is saying that we ought to stay on our knees twenty-four hours a day. But he is saying that we ought to be in an attitude of prayer twenty-four hours a day. Look at this in Psalms 5:3; *"My voice shalt thou hear in the morning, O Lord; in the morning will I direct my prayer unto thee, and will look up."* The Psalmist knew what it was to start His day off with the Lord.

I am not going to say to you that you have to have your daily devotions in the morning. I realize there some people are night people. Others will have their devotions in the afternoon. But I will say to you very plainly and very clearly that you do need, every morning, to spend some time with the Lord in prayer. Don't ignore God in the morning and expect to have a heart attitude of loving the Lord and being able to talk with Him throughout the day, if you don't start your day out right.

Notice in Psalm 55 what the Psalmist has to say. *“Evening, and morning, and at noon, will I pray, and cry aloud: and he shall hear my voice.”* The Bible tells us here that the Psalmist had at least three set times when he took time away to spend with the Lord. Think about that for a moment. I believe what the Lord is telling us is not necessarily that we have to do it first thing in the morning, and then at noon when the clock strikes twelve and then again in the evening before we go to bed. But I believe what he is saying is that there was a pattern in his life. A pattern that every day he took time apart, not just one time during the day, but several times during the day that he would set aside a segment of time to just stop and again put his heart and his mind on the things of God.

That is what we need to do in our Christian lives. If the only time I stop and push myself to spend time with the Lord is in the morning, before that day is over the time of fellowship with the Lord early in the morning will have worn off. But if I will take some time somewhere in late morning or early afternoon and spend a little time with the Lord, and then a little more in the late afternoon and then a little more late at night, I find that those seasons cause me to bring my heart and my mind back to the things of God and keep me in an attitude of prayer in my daily life. I recommend to you that you set aside some time like that with the Lord.

INGREDIENTS OF PRAYER

What should make up the ingredients of a prayer life? I have borrowed the acrostic I read some time ago: A.C.T.S. Those are the four ingredients, basically, of a prayer life. I want to share those four things with you.

Adoration

Number one, your prayer life ought to be made up of Adoration. A is for adoring the Lord Jesus Christ. We can praise the Lord for who He is.

Notice what we read in Psalm 113:3, *“From the rising of the sun unto the going down of the same the Lord’s name is to be praised.”* Then again, we notice the Scripture says in Psalm 144:1-2, *“Blessed be the Lord my strength, which teacheth my hands to war, and my fingers to fight: My goodness, and my fortress; my high tower, and my deliverer; my shield, and he in whom I trust; who subdueth my people under me.”*

Then again, notice what it says in Psalm 146:1-2, *“Praise ye the Lord. Praise the Lord, O my soul. While I live will I praise the Lord: I will sing praises unto my God while I have any being.”* So the Psalmist often praised the Lord. You will find in Psalms 145 through 150 that those Psalms are completely consumed with the idea of praising God.

Let me share with you a verse of scripture that caught my attention while I was reading the Word today in Exodus 6. If I am going to praise God for who He is, then this Bible is literally going to be filled with ideas of things that I can be praising God for. Look at verse 5, God says here, *“And I have also heard the groaning of the children of Israel, whom the Egyptians keep in bondage; and I have remembered my covenant.”* If you were going to praise God and this verse was your text, what are some things you can draw from verse 5 to praise God for?

Answers:

1. God never forgets. God remembers well. He remembers His people. He’ll always remember what He has promised.

2. God is a hearing God. You could spend a lot of time right here. Thank God, He hears us when we cry. Have you ever prayed to God and said, “Lord, when are you going to do something about that?” Well, here is the nation of Israel who had prayed for some time and cried out to God. Some

may have thought that God had forgotten them, but God heard it. God understood it, and in His time God answered.

3. God keeps His Word. Isn't that something—His faithfulness. What a faithful God we have that we serve. Aren't you glad that our God, when He makes a promise, is going to be faithful to carry it out? He never promised to you or I anything that He cannot deliver on, that He will not deliver on. God is always faithful.

4. God is always on time. Isn't it funny how sometimes we think God is a little late? Do you ever get like that with the Lord? "Lord, how come so long? Why don't you hurry up? It seems like yesterday you should have taken care of this, it's just a little late now." But God is never late—He is always on time.

5. Our God is always there to deliver His people. And that is exactly what He did for the nation of Israel here.

6. Sometimes we don't get what we pray for. Here is the nation of Israel. They prayed a long time, and God could have answered their prayers long before He did. But He didn't because He knew that at that point in time what those people needed. So we see God's foreknowledge, God's omniscience, or all-knowledge. God is able to know all things and if He had delivered the nation of Israel a little earlier, they probably would not have appreciated what He had done for them.

We could go on all night. We could talk about God's truthfulness and more. But these are just some examples of how you can use the Word of God in your prayer life. Just that one little verse like Exodus 6:5 can fill your prayer life with adoration, with praises to God. You may think, "How in the world could I ever bow my head and pray even for five

minutes?” Maybe one of the reasons that your prayer life lacks luster, it lacks any attractiveness to you, is because you do not praise the Lord in your prayer life. The only thing you have done in your prayer life is to go to God and say, “Okay, God, hurry up and hand it over,” and then you walk away before He can even answer. Use the scriptures and find things to praise God for.

Confession

Number two, there should be Confession in your prayer life. The reason our prayers often are not answered is simply because there is sin that hinders between us and the Lord. In Isaiah 59:1-2, *“Behold, the Lord’s hand is not shortened, that it cannot save; neither his ear heavy, that it cannot hear: But your iniquities have separated between you and your God, and your sins have hid his face from you, that he will not hear.”* Our sins hold back God’s answer often in our prayer life, because God cannot have anything to do in the way of fellowship with us when there is sin that stands in the way.

We could talk about the sin of unforgiveness in Mark 11:25-26. We could talk about the sin of selfishness as presented in James 4:3, *“Ye have not because ye ask not. Ye ask, and receive not, because ye ask amiss, that ye may consume it upon your lusts.”* We could talk about the sin of lukewarmness in the book of Jeremiah 29:13, *“When ye shall search for me with all your heart, then will you find Me.”*

Maybe the reason our prayer life is not what it should be is because we are not confessing our sins and we are not with our whole heart seeking God. Maybe what we need to do when we begin to talk to God is to confess a lukewarmness. “Lord, I don’t feel like praying to you. I am not as hot as I should be.” Then confess to Him, also, “Lord I will not allow this to stop me from talking to you, however.”

That is a mistake some Christians make. Because they feel cool and indifferent to the things of God, they say, “Well I’ve got to wait until I feel better!” No, that is when you need to pray even more than you ever did before. That is the time when you are most susceptible to temptation and to falling.

We could talk about family conflicts in I Peter 3:7. The reason your prayers are hindered is because of family problems. You need to settle those family problems. In I John 1:9 we are told, *“If we confess our sins, He is faithful and just to forgive us our sins, and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness.”* Now the word confess there means very simply this: it means to agree with God that what we have done is sin. We have wronged God and we were the ones that were wrong. Don’t shove the problem off on everybody else who “made me do it,” but simply bear the burden of your own sin. Say to the Lord, “I am the one that has sinned. I’m the one that chose the sin, and I choose now to agree with you that it is wrong and it is wicked and I want it put away from my life.” God wants us to confess.

Thanksgiving

Third of all (ACTS) there should be Thanksgiving. First Thessalonians 5:18, a passage that is familiar, *“In everything give thanks: for this is the will of God in Christ Jesus concerning you.”* Our thankfulness really shows our appreciation to God. We ought to be thankful.

You need to be thankful for answered prayer, things that God has done in your life. I recommend to you that you keep some kind of a log, or some kind of a list of things that God does in your life when He answers prayer, so that in turn you can get on your knees and say, “Thank you, Lord for what you did.”

We as Christians need to cultivate thankfulness. In Ephesians 5:20 it says, *“Giving thanks always for all things unto God and the Father in the name of our Lord Jesus Christ.”* You may not be able to be thankful for something that has happened in your life. You may have some tragedy or some problem take place that you may not be able to honestly say, “God, I’m glad that you did this terrible thing in my life.” But you can thank God that He knew that it was going to happen. You can thank God that He put all things together and thank God that He knows how to bring good out of the bitter. You can be thankful that all things do work together for good.

So when problems and troubles happen in your life, try getting on your knees and saying, “Lord, I want to be thankful, maybe not for the problem itself, but thankful that in the midst of this problem that you are going to use it for your good and for the furtherance of the gospel of Jesus Christ.” If you get into a good prayer session with God in the midst of a problem, and you begin to really be thankful for God’s working in your life in the midst of that, you are going to be hard pressed to get up off your knees and go out complaining.

Supplication

Then, in your prayer life (ACTS) there ought to be Supplication. A request, or supplication, falls into two categories. In the first category we pray for **others**.

Turn over to I Timothy 2, verses 1 and 2, *“I exhort, therefore, first of all, supplications, prayers, intercessions, and giving of thanks, be made for all men; For kings, and for all that are in authority; that we may lead a quiet and peaceable life in all godliness and honesty.”*

Look at I Samuel 12:23, *“But God forbid that I should sin against the Lord in ceasing to pray for you.”* In other words, what Samuel was saying is that it is a sin not to pray for others. We ought to have some kind of a list of other people that we are praying for and needs in other people’s lives. I don’t like to just go down a prayer list and say, “God bless so and so and God bless so and so.” I like to have something specific to be able to pray about. It helps if you know where that other person is at, and some things they are going through. As you know that, you can pray more intelligently for that person.

You can literally walk through the Bible and find scriptural things to be praying for. Here is an interesting passage, one that I go to quite often. Ephesians 1:15-23. We will just pick a few verses. It says in verse 15, *“Wherefore I also, after I heard of your faith in the Lord Jesus, and love unto all the saints, cease not to give thanks for you, making mention of you in my prayers.”* Here is Paul’s thankfulness in his prayer life: Thankful for their love, thankful for their faith, thankful for their life for the Lord Jesus Christ.

Then in verse 17, *“That the God of our Lord Jesus Christ, the Father of glory, may give unto you the spirit of wisdom and revelation in the knowledge of him.”* Paul prays, “Lord, open up the eyes of these Ephesian Christians that they may know you more fully. That they may get a better glimpse of who you are and what you want them to be in turn. Lord, help them to be captivated with your sight.”

There are some places that I have been that I’ll never forget. If we were to ask, there would be some things that are close to your heart, places you have been or maybe people that you have known. The fact is, that if you ever get close to God, when you get a real understanding of who God is, there is no way that you can ever again fall in love with the

things of this world. When you fall in love with Jesus Christ, your eyes are turned away from worldly things. If you get captivated with Jesus Christ, my friend, and you will go forward for Him. You won't fall off into sin. These are things Paul was praying for in the Ephesian Christian's lives.

As you read throughout the New Testament, you will notice that the most important area to pray for is the spiritual well-being of people, not the physical well-being. I'm not against praying for someone who is sick. But, friend, spiritual matters are much more important. One good way to pray for someone who is sick, is that God would use that sickness to draw them closer to Him, and to be a witness to others around them.

Second, our supplications, our requests, should be for ourselves. Unfortunately, this is where most of us start in our prayer life. "God, I have all these problems, and you have to hurry up and do something for me." We forget all about praising Him. We forget all about confessing our sins that are keeping us from being able to get through with our prayers. We aren't thankful for what He has done for us. We forget to put others first. We just come to him like some kind of greedy dog.

Have you ever seen a dog when you carry a pail of food out to him? You don't see that dog coming up and wagging his tail and looking at you, and you put the food down and he just pays attention to you and he doesn't pay any attention to the food. Unless he is sick, that dog is jumping all over you, but it is not you that he is interested in, it is that pail of food that he wants! How much like a dog do we act when we go to God in prayer? We jump all over God, but we are not interested in God. We are not interested in fellowship with Him. We are not interested in praising Him. We are not even thankful for the things that He has already done for us. We just want something else for ourselves. Greed takes hold.

Now, it's not wrong to pray for things for yourself. But it is wrong to have that as the ultimate goal of your prayer life, as the only thing that catches your attention. Look in I Peter 5:7. I like this verse. *"Casting all your care upon him; for he careth for you."* Amen.

And then, of course, Philippians 4. We can't pass up without this. In verses 6 and 7 the scripture says, *"Be careful for nothing; (or, in other words, don't be anxious or worried) but in everything by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known unto God. And the peace of God, which passeth all understanding, shall keep your hearts and minds through Christ Jesus."*

God tells us to cast our cares and our burdens on Him. He tells us here to let our requests be made known unto Him. Everyone of you could probably make a list of things that you would like to see happen in your life, spiritual needs, physical needs, material needs or whatever. God says cast your cares upon Him. Cast your needs upon Him. That is His request of you. He is asking you to do that. So we have every right to go to Him and pray and ask for these things. We also must realize that our prayers need to be scriptural. "Lord, do according to your will."

CONCLUSION

Do you have a place to pray? Do you have a place where you just get alone with the Lord all by yourself, just get away and alone with God? You ought to have.

Do you have a time when you have a special season of prayer every day with the Lord? Now, I realize, as I have said, you ought to have a few seasons during the day, but do you have a time when you really talk to God? I believe that it is important that you have a time, and you have

a place where you can be alone and nobody else is around. One of the best things you can do is pray out loud. Praying out loud will keep your attention on what you are saying.

Third of all, **do you have a prayer list**? What do you need a prayer list for? A list will help you remember to pray for needs and for specific people's needs in their lives. A prayer list can be very helpful. The prayer list that I like is just our simple church directory, just going through it and praying over it. I find that is effective for me to be able to just pray down the list and talk to God about different families and needs that are there.

Number four, **do you thank God for answers to your prayers**? Do you have some kind of a record to remind you of what God has done? How much more, in a human sense, would we get from a person if we are thankful than if we are unthankful for what they do for us? I think that it must be much the same with God. For if we are unthankful, why should God do anything for us when we ask? Of course the reason He does what He does is because of Christ. I understand that. But unthankfulness is a mark of an unsaved man, of a reprobate, according to Romans 1. Yet how many Christians could it be said of them, they are unthankful people. We need to be thankful.

QUESTIONS ON PRAYER

1. God wants our prayers to be Scriptural and _____.
2. Why does the believer need to pray in Jesus' name?
 - a. He is commanded
 - b. Because of what Christ has done for us
 - c. Both of the above
3. Did the writer of Psalm 55 pray several times a day?
4. What are the four ingredients of a prayer life?
 - a.
 - b.
 - c.
 - d.
5. List some things for which you can praise God in your prayer life.
6. According to Isaiah 59:1-2, what can hinder our prayer life?
7. Ephesians 5:20 instructs us to give thanks always for what?
8. Whom should we pray for according to I Timothy 2:1,2?

9. What are we to cast on the Lord (I Peter 5:7)?
10. What are we to make known unto God? (Philippians 4:6)?
11. List several requests you have and pray this week that God will answer them.